

before he was due to be executed. The twelfth man, Martin Bormann, who was Hitler's closest aide in the last years of the war, had been tried and condemned in his absence. It was long believed he had fled to South America, but in the 1970s, a skeleton was dug up in the ruins of Berlin; DNA testing in 1998 confirmed that it was Bormann.

Follow-up trials

After the Trial of the Major War Criminals, there was a series of follow-up trials at Nuremberg between December 1946 and April 1949. However, growing differences among the Allies undermined cooperation, so these were not international courts but US military tribunals, even though they were held in the same place. There were trials against doctors who had experimented on prisoners and trials against industrialists who had used forced labor. In all, a further 185 individuals were indicted, and 12 were condemned to death.

Meanwhile in Japan, between April 1946 and November 1948, another international tribunal was

bringing 28 Japanese military leaders to trial. US general Douglas MacArthur had launched the process by arresting Japanese leaders in September 1945, when Japan's surrender brought World War II to an end. The following January, he approved the Charter of the International Military Tribunal for the Far East, called the Tokyo Charter. Like the London Charter, this laid out the way the trials would work.

The charter specified a similar system to Nuremberg, with three broad categories of crime. The charge of crimes against peace (class A charges) was brought against Japan's top leaders who had steered the war. War crimes and crimes against humanity (classes B and C) were brought against lower ranks. But unlike in Nuremberg, to be prosecuted for any of these latter two crimes, individuals first had to be charged with crimes against peace.

One other key difference from Nuremberg was that instead of four countries, there were 11 nations represented in Tokyo. Australia, Canada, China, France, British India, the Netherlands, New

“

Why don't you just shoot us?

Unknown Nazi war criminal, 1946

”

Zealand, the Philippines, the USSR, the United Kingdom, and the United States—all of which had been drawn into Japan's war—provided judges and prosecutors.

After 2 years, all 28 Japanese leaders tried were found guilty. Seven were condemned to death and hanged. The rest were given long prison sentences.

The aftermath

Many people found the experience of the Nuremberg and related trials a dispiriting one. All those attending had been through many weeks of listening to the horrors of the German crimes unfold.

Some continued to argue that it was indeed victor's justice. The Soviets were soon found to have massacred 22,000 captured Polish officers at Katyn in 1940, while hundreds of thousands of German civilians had been killed by the Allied bombing of Hamburg, Dresden, and other German cities. Harlan Stone, chief justice of the US Supreme Court at the time,

A total of 419 witnesses gave evidence at the International Military Tribunal for the Far East. The three defendants shown here are General Iwane Matsui, Colonel Kingoro Hashimoto, and General Kenji Doihara.

